

Activity 3.3a: Reflection Activity

What are some of the possible wisdoms behind the *ṣalāh* in Islam the way that it has been prescribed by Allah ﷻ, and the way we are told to practice it? Why does it have set times? Why does it have to be offered so often every single day? Why does it have specific prescribed actions like standing, bowing, and prostrating?

[illegible]

The daily *ṣalāh* prescribed in Islam is unique. It has specific timings with set actions, and is obligated to perform five times every day. In order to reach a higher level of perfection, we are required to do things exactly as they are prescribed. For example, when coding, if you miss even one bracket, then the code will not function as intended and will not give you the desired result. Similarly, we are required to pray in a specified manner in order to reach higher levels of closeness to Allah ﷻ. When we take some time to reflect on this, we come to appreciate that this is in fact one of the great blessings that Allah ﷻ has granted us. If our daily *ṣalāh* was not obligatory and did not have set times and actions, then we would most likely not pray at all or rarely pray. This would lead us to become negligent of Allah ﷻ, forget our purpose in this world, and not appreciate the true beauty of the religion of Islam. Our journey toward reaching our perfection would be very much jeopardized, and we would lose out on the worldly and spiritual benefits of *ṣalāh*. If there was not one set way to pray for everyone, then we would not be able to easily pray in congregation, and reap the benefits of coming together as a community to serve Allah ﷻ!

The main reason we pray is because Allah ﷻ has commanded and prescribed it for us; however we also see that the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ have given us many insights into some of the wisdoms behind *ṣalāh* and its form. Reflecting upon and appreciating the unique form of the Muslim prayer and its benefits may help us achieve more humbleness and better attentiveness during *ṣalāh*.

Activity 3.3b: Jigsaw!

Each student will receive one *ḥadīth* to read and reflect on for five minutes.

- **5 minutes:** Read your *ḥadīth* and write down one or two points of reflection, and one question that arises for you.
- **3 minutes:** Find all of the other students in your class with the same *ḥadīth*—this is now your expert group! Once you are in that group, each student will have a role (you can pick among yourselves who wants to do what): Discussion leader, recorder (takes notes), researcher (goes through everyone's notes and summarizes them), and presenter.
- **15 minutes:** In your expert group, reread the *ḥadīth* and discuss ideas, thoughts, and questions. As a group, come up with three key points that the presenter can share with the class in order to teach them about the *ḥadīth* that was assigned to your group.

Ḥadīth #1

Imām Muḥammad al-Bāqir عليه السلام said:

Ṣalāh reaffirms sincerity, and purifies a person from arrogance. ¹³

Ḥadīth #2

Imām Ja'far aṣ-Ṣādiq عليه السلام was asked about the wisdom behind *ṣalāh* when it causes people to become physically tired, and occupies them from fulfilling their other needs. In response, he replied:

*It has (many) reasons. If people were left without any instructions or reminder about the message of the Prophet ﷺ...they would have been misled like those before them were misled....Allah ﷻ wanted to make sure they do not forget the religion of Muḥammad ﷺ so He made *ṣalāh* obligatory upon them. They (are made to) remember five times a day...* ¹⁴

Ḥadīth #3

Imām 'Alī ar-Riḍā عليه السلام said:

*...it (meaning the *ṣalāh*) contains a regular remembrance of Allah ﷻ in the day and the night. This is so a servant does not forget one's Master and Cherisher and Creator...The remembrance of one's Creator, and standing before Him (should) stop one from sinning, and prevent one from different types of corruption.* ¹⁵

¹³ *Mizān Al-Ḥikmah*, P. 10572.

¹⁴ *Mizān Al-Ḥikmah*, P. 10576.

¹⁵ *Mizān Al-Ḥikmah*, P. 10577.